Decolonization

By 1905, European powers controlled most of the land on the African continent. However, there were two exceptions: Liberia, which had been populated by African-American former slaves, and Ethiopia, which had resisted colonization by Italy. France and Great Britain possessed most African colonies, but Germany, Spain, Belgium, Italy and Portugal had their own colonies as well. With colonialism, the African leaders lost not just the power over their territories, but also lost control of natural resources like gold and rubber.

Decolonization occurred with the withdrawal of European powers from their territories in Africa. The colonies were able to gain political and economic independence. The decolonization of Africa took place following the Second World War, when most of the territories became free from European rule. During the Cold War years, the people from remaining colonies organized independence movements and colonial powers withdrew their governments from African territory.

The first step toward decolonization took place in 1941 when the United States President Franklin D. Roosevelt and the British Prime Minister Winston Churchill met to discuss decolonization. They created a document known as the Atlantic Charter, which became very popular amongst politicians. Roosevelt introduced the independence of imperial colonies after a lot of consideration.

When World War II ended, the United States and the African Colonies pressured Britain to follow the terms stated in the Atlantic Charter. Some British people considered the African colonies to be of little use. They eventually introduced democratic governments at local levels in the colonies so they could rule for themselves.